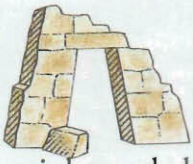


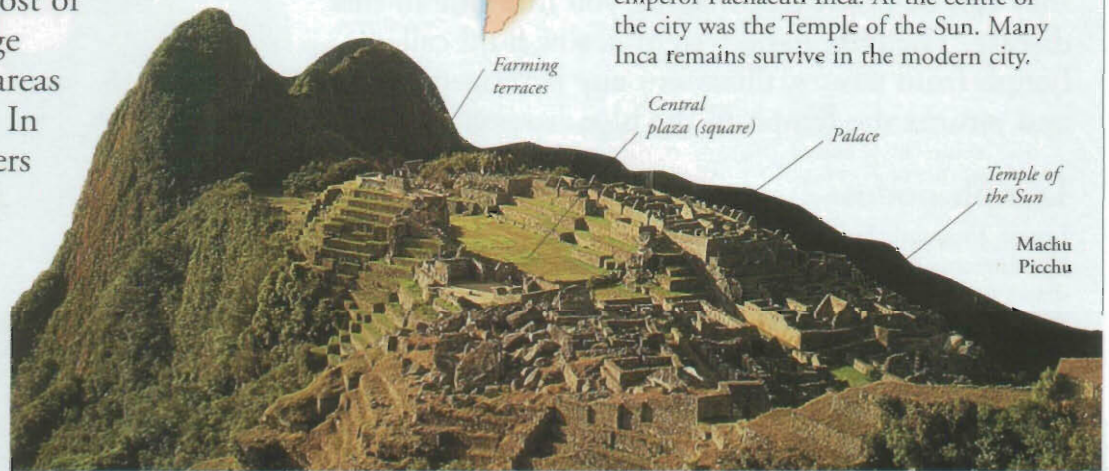
INCAS



IN THE 15TH CENTURY, the Incas created a great empire in Peru. They were a group of Native American peoples who used military might and skilled organization to build what was then one of the world's biggest nations. Their empire took in most of the great mountain range of the Andes and huge areas of desert and rainforest. In 1532, Spanish adventurers conquered the Incas.

Machu Picchu

The Incas built their cities using great blocks of rock so finely cut that they fitted together without cement. Machu Picchu, high in the Andes Mountains, is the most spectacular remaining example of Inca architecture. Its stone buildings clinging to the mountain could accommodate thousands of people.



Cuzco

The Inca capital was called Cuzco, from the Inca word meaning "centre". It is 3,400 m (11,000 ft) up in the mountains. Cuzco was an awe-inspiring city, made great by the emperor Pachacuti Inca. At the centre of the city was the Temple of the Sun. Many Inca remains survive in the modern city.

Inca industry

The state collected manufactured goods, such as food, wool, and clothing, which were kept in storehouses. Every town had at least two storehouses: one for the ruler, one for the rest of the people. Goods were transported by llamas along a large network of paved roads.

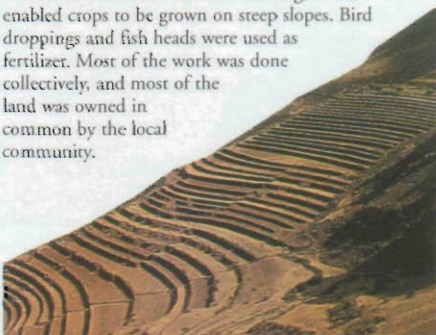
Quipus

The Incas had no system of writing, but they kept records by knotting different coloured strings on to a stick or cord known as a quipu. They could record figures such as the numbers of wool bales or the amount of births in a year using this method.



Agriculture

The Incas introduced terraced farming, which enabled crops to be grown on steep slopes. Bird droppings and fish heads were used as fertilizer. Most of the work was done collectively, and most of the land was owned in common by the local community.



Inca society

At the top of society were the Inca ruler and his relatives. They could be identified because they were allowed to enlarge their ears with huge ornaments. Some of the nobles left their palaces in Cuzco to rule outposts of the empire. Ordinary people were organized into groups of villages called ayllus. Each ayllu was governed by an elected council of elders. Sometimes the emperors moved groups of people around the empire, so that they could place loyal people in areas that were otherwise difficult to govern.



Workers

Inca workers produced some goods for themselves, and some for the emperor and nobles. These provided the state with the resources for public works and other royal projects.



Cup with emperor's portrait

Emperors

The Incas believed their rulers were descended from the Sun god, so they were worshipped as holy beings. This portrait of an Inca emperor decorates a cup used in religious rituals.

Religion

Chief of the gods was the creator Viracocha, who was worshipped by the Inca priesthood and nobility. Next in importance was the Sun god, Inti, claimed by royal Incas as their ancestor. Other Inca deities included gods of the Moon and stars. The earth god was also central, because the Incas relied on farming for wealth and food.



Sun god

Pachacuti

Pachacuti Inca was crowned in 1438. With his son, Topa Inca, Pachacuti enlarged the territory of the Inca state. He came to dominate many provinces, was a great organizer, and an effective administrator.



Spanish conquest

Shortly before the Spanish ships reached Peru's coast, civil war broke out among the Incas. The Spaniards, led by Francisco Pizarro (c.1475–1541), took advantage of this division and captured the Inca Empire for the King of Spain.



Spanish coins

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